

France 2026

The Bresler / Tussey Family Expedition

A Journey Through History, Culture, and Family

Briefing #1: Introduction

Part I — Why France?

Every great journey begins long before anyone boards a plane.

It begins in conversations around the dinner table. It begins with maps spread across a kitchen counter, restaurant ideas scribbled onto an itinerary, and the quiet excitement that comes from imagining places you've never seen—or places you've been longing to return to. Long before the first suitcase is packed, a journey begins to take shape in the imagination.

That is what these briefings are meant to do.

Over the coming weeks, we'll explore the history, culture, landscapes, and traditions of France before we ever set foot there. Think of these chapters as part travel guide, part history lesson, and part family story. My hope is that by the time we arrive at Charles de Gaulle Airport, France will already feel a little familiar—not because we've been there before, but because we've begun to understand the story we're about to step into. My hope is that these briefings help us arrive not only a little more prepared, but a little more curious about what we are about to experience.

Our journey itself begins in a fitting way.

We'll land in Paris, arriving from multiple destinations in the United States, greet each other, pick up our rental cars, and almost immediately head west toward Rennes. We'll spend our first night with the Ferradini family, who welcomed Kate into their home when she was an exchange student more than thirty years ago. From there we'll continue to Mont Saint-Michel, Normandy, Paris, and finally board a high-speed train that will carry us the length of the country to Provence and the Mediterranean.

Before we travel through France...

let's first understand why France is such an extraordinary place.

There is a reason more people visit France than any other country on Earth.

It is not because France has the tallest mountains, the best beaches, the greatest food, or the most beautiful cities—although it has a compelling case for all of those things.

France is special because it feels like many countries woven together into one.

Over the next two weeks, we will travel through regions that were once separate worlds. They spoke different languages, developed different traditions, prepared different cuisines, built different homes, and often looked in completely different directions for their prosperity.

The fishermen and farmers of Normandy, the merchants of Paris, and the sailors and villagers of Provence all eventually became French. Yet each region retained a character that remains unmistakable today.

That is one of the great joys of traveling through France.

The country changes as you move through it.

The landscape changes.

The architecture changes.

The cuisine changes.

The light changes.

Even the rhythm of daily life changes.

Few countries have stood at the center of so much history for so long.

Long before France existed, Celtic tribes known as the Gauls inhabited these lands. Roman legions arrived and left behind roads, cities, laws, and ideas that still shape the country today. Vikings sailed up its rivers and established settlements that would become Normandy. Medieval kings built castles and cathedrals that still dominate skylines. Explorers crossed oceans. Philosophers transformed ideas. Revolutionaries challenged monarchies. Emperors marched across Europe.

During this trip, we will encounter traces of every one of those eras.

France is not simply a place where history happened.

In many ways, it is one of the places where much of Western history was written.

For our family, however, France is also something much more personal.

More than thirty years ago, Kate spent her junior year of high school living in Rennes. She learned the language, immersed herself in everyday French life, and discovered something that many travelers eventually come to understand: the greatest rewards of travel are not found in checking famous places off a list, but in becoming—if only for a little while—a participant in another culture.

Rennes has remained part of our family's story ever since. Kate and I returned there to celebrate our first wedding anniversary, when I surprised her with a trip through Rennes, Normandy, and Paris. Now, years later, we'll return once again—this time not only with our children, but with the entire Tussey family as well.

Twelve of us.

Eight cousins.

One shared adventure.

Before we visit famous monuments...

before we stand beneath the Eiffel Tower...

before we wander through the Louvre...

our first evening in France will be spent with the family who welcomed Kate into their home all those years ago.

Friendship.

Hospitality.

A relationship that has endured across decades and continents.

There could hardly be a more fitting beginning to our adventure.

Part II — A Shared Adventure

This trip is about more than France.

It is also about the people with whom we will experience it.

The Breslers and Tusseys do not get to spend as much time together as we would like. Life has a way of filling calendars. School, sports, work, and geography all compete for our attention, and before long another season has passed.

For two weeks, that changes.

For two weeks, twelve of us—eight cousins, ranging in age from seven to seventeen, along with four adults—will share trains, apartments, boats, beaches, museums, markets, restaurants, and countless moments that none of us can fully anticipate today.

That, perhaps more than anything else, is what makes this trip special.

Every family has a handful of experiences that gradually become part of its shared story.

The vacations that are still talked about years later.

The unexpected detours that somehow became the highlight of the trip.

The meals everyone remembers.

The jokes that never quite stop being funny.

The photographs that instantly transport you back to another place and another time.

My hope is that this journey becomes one of those family stories.

Not because everything will go perfectly.

It won't.

We'll miss a turn somewhere.

Someone will get tired. (*Nora...I'm looking at you.*)

Someone will get grumpy. (*I'm mostly looking at myself.*)

The weather won't cooperate every day.

Plans will change.

And years from now, those probably won't be the things we remember.

Instead, we'll remember watching Mont Saint-Michel slowly emerge from the horizon.

We'll remember standing together above Omaha Beach, honoring the extraordinary sacrifice made there.

We'll remember the first glimpse of the Eiffel Tower.

We'll remember wandering through markets in Provence.

We'll remember boat rides on the Mediterranean.

We'll remember dinners that lasted longer than expected.

We'll remember afternoons in the pool beneath a bright Mediterranean sky.

We'll remember laughter around a table.

We'll remember the conversations that happened because there was finally enough time to have them.

Each of us will carry home a different collection of memories.

Some will remember the history.

Some will remember the beaches.

Some will remember the food.

Some will remember the cousins.

Some will remember something no one else even noticed.

And that is exactly how it should be.

One of the wonderful things about family travel is that no two people take the same trip.

We experience the same places, yet each of us sees them through our own eyes.

Years from now, when someone mentions Mont Saint-Michel, a sunset in Paris, the lavender fields of Provence, or a boat anchored off the coast near Cannes, twelve different stories will come rushing back.

Together, those stories become something larger.

They become part of our family's history.

There is another reason this trip feels special.

It is happening at a wonderful moment in our lives.

The oldest cousins are beginning to think about college and the adventures that await them beyond home.

The youngest are old enough that these experiences will become real memories rather than photographs in a family album.

Kate first came to Rennes more than thirty years ago as an exchange student. We returned together for our first wedding anniversary, and now we'll return once again—this time not only with our children, but with the entire Tussey family as well.

For many in our group, this will be their first opportunity to experience France—and for the Tusseys, their first family adventure abroad.

And all of us have the opportunity to spend two uninterrupted weeks together—something that becomes increasingly difficult as life rolls on.

These windows do not stay open forever.

Perhaps that is one of the reasons travel matters.

It invites us to recognize moments while we are experiencing them instead of only appreciating them in hindsight.

Maybe this will become one of those family stories that gets retold for years.

Maybe it will simply be two wonderful weeks together in a remarkable country.

Either way, it will be time well spent.

France will provide the setting.

Our family will provide the story.

Part III — The Three Acts of Our Journey

Before I introduce the three acts of our journey, there is one person who deserves special recognition.

Every expedition needs a captain—someone to imagine the route before anyone else can follow it.

For us, that person is Mom / Aunt Kate.

Over the past several months, she has poured an extraordinary amount of thought into creating the architecture of this trip. From where we'll stay and how we'll travel, to balancing history with relaxation, museums with beaches, cities with villages, and planned activities with time simply to wander, she has thoughtfully designed an experience rather than simply booked a vacation.

These briefings are simply my way of helping all of us begin that journey a little before departure.

The architecture is hers.

Now we get to step inside it together.

Like every good story, this one unfolds in three acts.

Each has its own character.

Each has its own pace.

Each builds naturally toward the next.

Act I: Atlantic France

We begin in Brittany and Normandy.

It is a thoughtful beginning.

Our first evening will be spent not in a hotel, but with the Ferradini family, whose friendship has been part of Kate's life for more than thirty years. Rennes has remained part of our family's story ever since. It was also where Kate and I celebrated our first wedding anniversary, when I surprised her with a return trip through Rennes, Normandy, and Paris.

From there, history takes center stage.

Mont Saint-Michel.

Normandy.

The American Cemetery.

The beaches of D-Day.

These first few days invite us to slow down, look back, and understand some of the events that shaped both France and the United States.

It simply feels like the right way to begin.

Act II: Paris

Then comes Paris.

The pace picks up in the City of Light.

We'll spend five days exploring one of the world's great cities, balancing famous landmarks with neighborhoods, museums with cafés, and ambitious sightseeing with time to simply wander.

There will be plenty of opportunities to dive more deeply into Paris later in these briefings.

For now, it is enough to know that this part of the trip is about exploration.

We'll walk.

A lot.

We'll discover that Paris often reveals itself between the famous attractions—in the markets, along the Seine, in quiet streets, and around café tables.

Act III: Provence & the Mediterranean

Our final act begins with one of the great pleasures of European travel: boarding a train and watching a country gradually unfold outside the window.

By the time we step off in Aix-en-Provence, the rhythm of the trip begins to change.

For the first time, we'll unpack once and stay put.

The day trips will still be there.

So will the beaches, markets, boats, villages, and restaurants.

But this final chapter is intentionally different.

There is more room to breathe.

More room for long dinners.

More room for conversations.

More room for afternoons by the pool.

More room to enjoy being together without feeling that we need to be somewhere else.

The Mediterranean has a way of encouraging that.

It seems like a fitting place for our journey to conclude.

Every trip develops its own rhythm.

Some days will be full.

Others will be wonderfully unplanned.

Some moments we'll anticipate for months.

Others will surprise us completely.

That is part of the joy of travel.

The itinerary Kate designed gives us a framework.

The experiences we share within it are what will ultimately define the journey.

The chapters that follow will prepare us for each of these three acts in greater detail.

For now, it is enough to know that, with this briefing, the adventure has already begun.

Part IV — What to Notice

Travel has a way of teaching us something about ourselves.

Sometimes that happens in famous places.

More often, it happens in smaller moments.

Here are some of those moments you may get to enjoy on our journey.

A bakery opening in the morning.

A church bell ringing across a village.

A market slowly filling with people.

A café table where no one seems in a hurry to leave.

A different way of greeting a shopkeeper.

A meal that unfolds at its own pace.

France is full of these moments, but they are easy to miss if we are rushing from one scheduled stop to the next.

So as we travel, I hope we all try to notice a few things.

Notice how the regions change.

How Brittany feels different from Normandy.

How Paris feels different from both.

How Provence and the Mediterranean seem to operate by another rhythm altogether.

Notice the food.

Not just what is served, but how people eat.

Notice the bread, the markets, the cheese, the seafood, the crêpes, the olive oil, the rosé, and the small rituals that surround a meal.

Notice the buildings.

The stone villages.

The churches, monasteries, and cathedrals.

The cafés.

The shutters.

The way old and new live side by side.

Notice the sounds.

French spoken quickly around us.

Scooters on city streets.

Chairs scraping across café terraces.

Waves against a boat.

Cicadas in the south.

Notice the light.

The gray-blue tones of Normandy.

The glow of Paris in the evening.

The brightness of the southern sun.

And notice the people.

Now, like many countries, France comes with its share of stereotypes—some held by Americans about the French, and some the French may hold about Americans. In my experience, genuine curiosity and a little kindness have a way of making those stereotypes fade into the background. A smile, a "bonjour," and an openness to doing things a little differently go a remarkably long way.

We are going to experience another culture through our own eyes, together as a family of adventurers.

I hope this will be one of the best aspects of the trip.

Because if we notice carefully enough, France will give us far more than beautiful places to remember.

It may simply leave us seeing the world a little differently.

Part V — What We Hope to Bring Home

At the end of this journey, our suitcases will probably be a little heavier.

There may be a few bottles of wine.

Some local pottery.

A favorite sweater.

Perhaps a small souvenir that, years from now, will quietly remind us of a place or a moment.

But I hope the most meaningful things we bring home won't fit in a suitcase.

I hope we bring home a deeper appreciation for a country that has enriched the world in so many ways.

I hope we better understand why France is not simply one place, but many distinct regions, each with its own story to tell.

I hope we return with a greater appreciation for noticing the small moments that so often become the memorable ones.

I hope the children come home with a curiosity to continue exploring the world.

I hope the adults do too.

Most of all, I hope we bring home a collection of shared stories.

The conversations.

The laughter.

The unexpected detours.

The quiet moments.

The stories that will gradually become part of our family's history.

Years from now, the exact sequence of museums, restaurants, and reservations may begin to blur.

But I suspect we'll still remember how France made us feel.

And we'll remember experiencing it together.

These briefings have been my way of beginning the journey a little early.

Now it is almost time for the real adventure to begin.

I can't wait to experience it with all of you.